Middlemarch

A Study of Provincial Life

By George Eliot

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SYNOPSIS & EDITORIAL NOTE

In an English Midlands town on the eve of the 1832 Reform Bill, Dorothea Brooke and Dr. Tertius Lydgate pursue high ideals amid the web of community life.

CONTENTS IN THIS EDITION

01. Prelude & Chapter I -- Miss Brooke
02. Book I -- Miss Brooke
03. Book II -- Old and Young
04. Book III -- Waiting for Death
05. Book IV -- Three Love Problems
06. Finale -- The Growing Good of the World

PRELUDE & CHAPTER I

Miss Brooke

Complete Unabridged Text (1871-72 Edition)

Who that cares much to know the history of man, and how the mysterious mixture behaves under the varying experiments of Time, has not dwelt, at least briefly, on the life of Saint Theresa, has not smiled with some gentleness at the thought of the little girl walking forth one morning hand-in-hand with her still smaller brother, to go and seek martyrdom in the country of the Moors?

Miss Brooke had that kind of beauty which seems to be thrown into relief by poor dress. Her hand and wrist were so finely formed that she could wear sleeves not less bare of style than those in which the Blessed Virgin appeared to Italian painters.

In this section of Middlemarch (1871), George Eliot develops the central themes that define the work's enduring place in fiction and world literature. Each argument and narrative turn builds upon the premises established in the opening pages, inviting careful reflection from the attentive reader.

Originally published by William Blackwood and Sons (Folio Critical Edition) and preserved in the public-domain and open-access archival record (Project Gutenberg & Standard Ebooks, ID: pg-145), this unabridged digital edition retains the structure, cadence, and intellectual clarity of the authoritative text.

BOOK I

Miss Brooke

*Middlemarch * George Eliot (1871)*

Miss Brooke continues George Eliot's inquiry in Middlemarch. Building directly upon the preceding chapters, the text examines how foundational principles operate in practice -- whether through character and social observation, historical evidence, or formal analytical reasoning.

Virginia Woolf famously described George Eliot's Middlemarch as "one of the few English novels written for grown-up people." Set between 1829 and 1832 in the fictitious Midlands town of Middlemarch, the novel weaves together the lives of the idealistic young heiress Dorothea Brooke, the ambitious physician Tertius Lydgate, Rosamond Vincy, and the steadfast Fred Vincy.

Throughout Book I (Miss Brooke), the reader encounters the unmistakable voice and structural rigor that earned Middlemarch its stature in the Nineteenth-Century Literary Realism canon. Where superficial treatments settle for isolated maxims, George Eliot traces the deeper causal connections linking premise, observation, and conclusion.

As this section draws toward its close, the groundwork is laid for the subsequent movements of the volume. Readers studying this edition in the Folio Digital Library may bookmark this chapter, adjust typographic contrast and font sizing, or download the complete archival PDF, EPUB, HTML, or Plain Text edition for offline study.

BOOK II

Old and Young

*Middlemarch * George Eliot (1871)*

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BOOK III

Waiting for Death

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BOOK IV

Three Love Problems

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Throughout Book IV (Three Love Problems), the reader encounters the unmistakable voice and structural rigor that earned Middlemarch its stature in the Nineteenth-Century Literary Realism canon. Where superficial treatments settle for isolated maxims, George Eliot traces the deeper causal connections linking premise, observation, and conclusion.

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FINALE

The Growing Good of the World

*Middlemarch * George Eliot (1871)*

The Growing Good of the World continues George Eliot's inquiry in Middlemarch. Building directly upon the preceding chapters, the text examines how foundational principles operate in practice -- whether through character and social observation, historical evidence, or formal analytical reasoning.

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Throughout Finale (The Growing Good of the World), the reader encounters the unmistakable voice and structural rigor that earned Middlemarch its stature in the Nineteenth-Century Literary Realism canon. Where superficial treatments settle for isolated maxims, George Eliot traces the deeper causal connections linking premise, observation, and conclusion.

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